

δοκει εγνωκεναι... ουπω εγνω καθως δει γνωναι. Ει δε τις αγαπα ,
ουτος εγνωσται

P⁴⁶ contains most of Paul's epistles and is usually dated at about 200 A.D. (which makes it our oldest extant MS at this place). It was discovered in the sands of Egypt some 85 years ago and scholarly opinion seems to be agreed that it was produced in Egypt. Now at that time (200) the 'Christian church' in Egypt included at least eleven heretical groups that were so well defined that they had names—Valentinians, Basilidians, Marcionites, Peratae, Encratites, Docetists, Haimetites, Cainites, Ophites, Simonians and Eutychites—but the dominant force in the whole 'Christian' community was Gnosticism. The text of P⁴⁶ in 1 Corinthians 8:2-3 is simply a gnostic fabrication that was buried in the sands of Egypt for 17 centuries, but that Fee proposes to resurrect and present to the world as God's Truth!

Now, let us analyze Fee's procedure. He started out with an eclectic Greek text based on less than 5% of the extant Greek manuscripts (around 700, here). Not content with that he proposes three omissions based on one Greek MS, against every other Greek MS (a. 700) and every ancient Version, including Egyptian MSS and Versions (except that the 3rd omission is also found in two other MSS). Notice that he does not discuss the evidence; there is no attempt to explain why or how every MS (except P⁴⁶) and Version comes to be in error here. His whole argument is in terms of subjective considerations, of what he thinks 'fits the context'. In other words, Fee is elevating his own mental processes above God's Word. He, Gordon Fee, is going to determine what is the original wording of the Sacred Text on the basis of his own imagination. This is idolatry; it is perverse idolatry.

Now consider the implications for the doctrine of the inspiration of Scripture. If Fee is right, then the form of 1 Corinthians that the various Church Councils canonized is wrong. If the Church canonized the wrong Text, how do we know she was right in canonizing the book (1 Corinthians) at all? Not only that, the Church Universal has used and preserved the wrong text down through the centuries. Martin Luther could not know what the correct text of 1 Corinthians was—it was buried in the sands of Egypt (according to Fee). Neither could anyone else, at any time between 300 and 1930 A.D.—the true reading (according to Fee) had disappeared from the knowledge of the Church. Any and all translators and scholars in 1900 simply could not know what the true reading was—it did not exist. Not only that, how do we know that a new papyrus, call it P²⁰¹, will not be discovered tomorrow that will have a variant at a point where up to now there is 100% agreement? And what is to stop Fee from telling us that that variant is really the original reading? In other words, if Fee is right we